

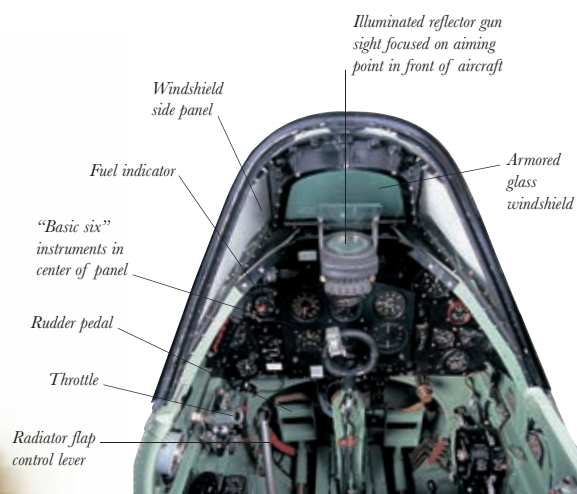


SCRAMBLING

Pilots demonstrate running towards their Spitfires after receiving a general alert from coastal observation stations. However fast they scrambled, the RAF fighters were rarely able to reach sufficient altitude quickly enough to deny the high-flying Messerschmitts the advantage at the start of an encounter.

LOADING AMMUNITION

Mechanics feed the weaponry of a Spitfire with belts of ammunition of 250–300 rounds. Those Spitfires with a “universal” wing could be configured in three ways: eight machine guns (four on each wing), two cannon and four machine guns, or four cannon.



COMPACT COCKPIT

Like most fighter cockpits, that of the Spitfire was compact and pilot comfort was not a prime consideration. The heart of its instrument panel was the standard blind-flying panel, containing the six essential instruments for recording speed, attitude, altitude, vertical speed, and turn and slip.

